

FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 26

MISSISSIPPI

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — a cross-location dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Mississippi's family courts and child-welfare system.

71

MISSISSIPPI FAMILIES ON RECORD · 147 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 16 MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING TIME

DATA AS OF
NOVEMBER 11, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
33 OF 82

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS · MISSISSIPPI

A name appears below only after 3 or more independent families have named the same actor in Mississippi. Submitter names, emails, and contact details are never published. Comments below are direct family reports — one per family — with all identifying information removed.

Amanda Heitmueller

THERAPIST / COUNSELOR · FORREST · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"See my Forrest/ Lamar Complaint..I. PARTIES Plaintiff is an adult resident citizen of Lamar County, Mississippi and the biological mother of three minor children. Defendant is a licensed clinical social worker who, at all relevant times, provided court-involved therapeutic services in connection with custody proceedings involving Plaintiff's children. II. JURISDICTION AND VENUE This Court has subject matter jurisdiction pursuant to Article 6, Section 156 of the Mississippi Constitution and Miss. Code Ann. § 9-7-81. Venue is proper in Lamar County, Mississippi because the acts and omissions giving rise to this Complaint occurred in connection with proceedings before the Lamar County Chancery Court, and the resulting harm to Plaintiff occurred in this jurisdictionIII. FACTUAL ALLEGATIONS A. Limited Scope of Appointment Defendant was appointed by the Lamar County Chancery Court to provide therapeutic counseling services to the minor children. Defendant was not appointed to conduct: a custody evaluation, a forensic evaluation, a psychological examination of either parent, or any formal assessment of parental fitness. Defendant did not evaluate Plaintiff, did not perform psychological t"*

> *"Did not advocate for child with court as she assured the child, mother, & attorney that she would. She made excuses for not appearing at trial or emergency custody hearing like she said she would. Negligent disregard for children trapped in abusive situations & families trying to leave/heal from abuse & PTSD."* LAMAR

> *"Ignored evidence"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/ms-amanda-heitmueller/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Cherieka Witherspoon white

GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · LEE COUNTY MISSISSIPPI · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Has not been to children's placement ever (7 months total), making kinship travel to her to see children (never doing her legal duty) disregards children's statements, threatens child with custody/placements if said parent doesn't cooperate"*

> *"Misrepresentation of case facts. Lies about recommendations from therapist. Is very buddy buddy with cps workers. Lies in court."*

> *"Delay reunification not interested in doing her job correctly"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/ms-cherieka-witherspoon-white/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

K. Lee Stribling

GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · LAMAR · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Ignored evidence, demonstrated bias, and relied on tampered documentation. He reviewed a CPS report and met with counsel but took no action. Nineteen months later, at trial, he claimed that what I had done was "so horrific and I was abusive," even though he had already reviewed the same records months earlier. The evidence is in his itemized billing. His actions ultimately cost me custody. The judge ordered both parties to undergo psychological evaluations. My ex-husband never completed a psychological evaluation, but I did, and mine was used against me. The GAL justified my ex-husband's failure to complete the evaluation while using mine against me while he called me crazy. I also have a recording of the CPS worker stating that someone falsified documentation. In addition, I have a recording of the court-appointed therapist saying, "They gave me your psychological evaluation right before I got on the stand and told me to focus on that." Former GAL (permanently withdrew), did not investigate, biased, absolutely unprofessional. Taking CPS allegations and claiming them as facts; CPS caseworker stated there were falsified documents in a recorded conversation; ignoring serious medical concerns; tampering with medical documents; traveling from New Orleans to Hattiesburg, Mississippi, which appears strange; aggressive emails; withdrawing, then coming back for a hearing, and then permanently withdrawing from the case; and much more as well."*

> *"Absolutely awful. Unilaterally raised his rates and billed for 3 years with a higher rate than the court order granted him when appointing him. Ignored evidence. Suppressed evidence. Told my ex I was on meth. Called me a liar. Kicked my youngest son out of his office. Sent that son home with his abusive father the night of trial day #2 — immediately following that son testifying against his dad in court — which went against the GAL's narrative. And so much more. My bar complaint (which was ignored) had 30+ exhibits of evidence attached."*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/ms-k-lee-stribling/complaint-packet
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01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Sheila Smallwood

JUDGE · LAMAR · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Lacked due process, child endangerment, ignoring Father's failure to comply, removing children for seeking medical help, "no transcripts," speaking to a child under the state age requirement with the transcript missing, allowing medical neglect, allowing Father to refuse to communicate despite joint legal custody, holding hearings without proper notice on one end, improper balance of treatment, ignoring self-harm and suicide threats, and plenty more."*

> *"Heard my initial filing. Granted DAPO on the spot based on all the evidence I brought with me. Made me promise I would never go back to my ex. Told me to get my kids and go to my parents for safety until things could be legally figured out."* LAMAR COUNTY 10TH DISTRICT

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/ms-sheila-smallwood/complaint-packet
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Public threshold rule: Names are grouped conservatively by normalized spelling, role, and location. Common titles, punctuation, casing, and middle initials collapse together. Close misspellings are not auto-merged without admin review. Only family-direct submissions count toward the public threshold.

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

MISSISSIPPI AT A GLANCE.

Across 71 Mississippi families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST	WENT PRO SE
147	**$49,500**	**16**	**46.5%**
71 of 71 families reported child counts	median across 26 families reporting 3+ categories	of parenting time	33 of 71 who answered; 25 of 71 ran out of money

SUBMISSIONS	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN	COUNTIES REPRESENTED
71	2.1	71 of 71	33

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Mississippi families — and families across every represented location — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

03 THE COST OF MISSISSIPPI FAMILY COURT

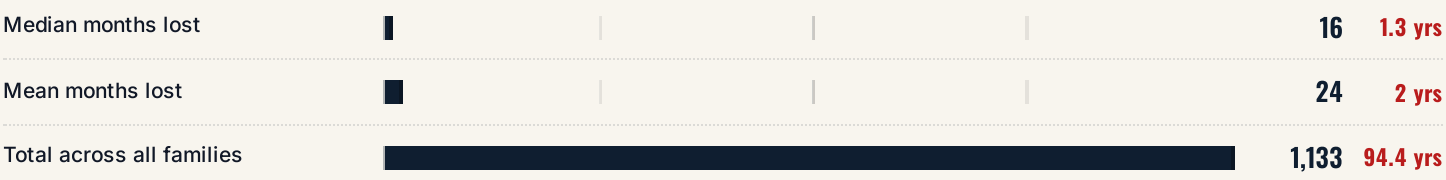
Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	44	$8,000	$30,156	$1,326,878
Lost Wages	28	$6,000	$33,838	$947,455
Other Court Fees	16	$188	$2,483	$39,726
Therapy / Evaluations	26	$1,235	$3,167	$82,339
Reunification Services	14	$26	$437	$6,119
GAL Fees	29	$1,500	$4,691	$136,051
Asset Loss [1]	26	$21,500	—	—
Median Family Burden (26 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	$49,500	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least $1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median ($21,500) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS



04 WHO IS REPORTING · MISSISSIPPI

Most families documenting in Mississippi are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children. Percentages below use only families who answered that specific topic.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed	39	55%
Case closed: within last 2 years	8	11%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago	7	10%
Not provided	6	8%
Not in court but still affected	5	7%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS	32	45%
Family Court Only	25	35%
CPS Only	11	15%
Unknown	3	4%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years	21	30%
6 months – 1 year	14	20%
3 – 5 years	12	17%
Less than 6 months	11	15%
5 – 10 years	8	11%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only	18	25%
Children in Foster Care	15	21%
Full Custody	14	20%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access	13	18%
50/50 Joint	8	11%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Lamar	8	12%
Harrison	6	9%
Forrest	6	9%
Lee	5	8%
Jackson	5	8%
Rankin	3	5%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)	24	34%
Other	13	18%
High Conflict Divorce	9	13%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)	8	11%
Medical CPS (Medical Child Abuse allegations, disagreement with doctors)	5	7%

05 PARENT VOICES — MISSISSIPPI

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Mississippi comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.

> *Stolen my children's childhoods. Ripped our family apart. Placed a child permanently with his abusive father. Aided and facilitated abuse and the abuser. Opened my eyes to the real system — it is NOT "broken".. it's a well oiled, smooth running.. money making, family breaking [...]*
>
> — ALEX

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Took three healthy kids and emotionally abused them, along with their mother and maternal family, through repeated questioning by the court therapist, CPS, judge, and GAL. Took the children away from a loving mother based on false allegations, without due process or objective [...]

— MISSISSIPPI PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM MISSISSIPPI

My name is Jacqueline Phillips of Greenville MS and CPS have lied and kidnapped my kids in Greenville MS for a lie and the youth court judge is a drunk and a lier she let kids get beat and rape in foster care and don't care

— BENITEZ

This system is what creates drug users and abusers. This system that is sworn to protect the innocent and vulnerable children do nothing but destroy families and lives or hundreds if not thousands. All they see when they see kids is a dollar sign.

— MICHELLE

My family, one of the closest I have ever know, will forever be destroyed and we can never get back what they have stolen from us. The Court and its actors, along with who has my kids have completely turned my kids against me and alienated us and my soul will carry a scar [...]

— DEBORAH

Judge stated I would receive more financially because abuse was proven; opposite happened AND house given to husband

— JANICE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *This court denied placement with family after they stole the father's rights. After being approved by ICPC was still denied. This family court system is determined to take children. To adopt when there are many kids waiting and available.*
>
> — MARIE

It has destroyed our family and our children got spread out.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I do think that people making false claims over and over to cps should be punished it cause so much heartache and loss in families

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

No Words that can accurately describe the Lost. However these Judges are Temporary. I serve an Eternal Judge that will restore what the Locust have stolen!!

— ASHLEY

Clay County CPS sold my newborn son to the highest bidder & I haven't been allowed to see him since 2021.

— JAMIE

My mother and ex stepfather made up false accusations and took custody away from me with no warning or CPS involvement. I have severe CPTSD from it now

— HANNA

Its caused and continues to cause extreme trauma to me and my children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Taken my sons away (kidnapped/trafficked) Given them to abusers making them suicidal and not trusting anyone for help/hopeless and destroyed their physical and mental health

— DANA

Family court didn’t just make a ruling—it tore my children from their mother against their will and silenced their voices in the process. What was supposed to protect them broke their trust in the very system meant to help, and we’re still working to heal from that damage.

— RAMONA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *Child Protection Services are suppose to protect children and if able under circumstances of reportance help in every way to keep families together. Their legal duty is to investigate, listen to children and family and do what they can to keep a family together, reunify, or [...]*
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

I've been in my kids life since the beginning but now I can only talk to them on the phone

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

God is the only true one that knows the truth. No words can begin to explain what cps has done

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The lowndes County Family court is not looking for the best interest of the children. All they see is dollar signs. They don't care about the trauma they cause when they rip families apart as long as they get there daycare vouchers and federal funds.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My kids have lost faith in a system that was supposed to get help for their dad. GAL has sided with the abuser...their dad....we have proof. The kids have been humiliated by GAL going to school to pull them from class to talk to them...when she privately met with them multiple [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Emboldened an abuser to continue to abuse & oppress a mother & children after physical exodus. I've been disillusioned & no longer trust the system to help victims of abuse or represent the best interest of the children. I've learned the system is for abusers, not for their [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

my family has been placed into crisis due to their actions. We have been financially hurt and emotionally abused due to their negligence and false claims.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system I was (finally) brave enough to contact, the one I held in such high esteem for protection and "doing what's right," has compounded the harm I was seeking safety from and punished me for trying to protect my children and myself.

— ALEX

It has taken out souls we can't breathe it's like there drowning and I can't help

— ASHLEY JEAN

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *Stripped a child from a Loving family. We are still stalked harassed bullluef. One sister not allowed to be apart of her sister life. Full custody of 1 child but not allowed to see the other*
>
> — KRISTEN

I followed the rules, told the truth, and still lost my son to a system that protects power over people

— ALEXIS

It has caused me so much emotional stress. I can't eat or sleep. I'm lucky to have a very understanding boss or I probably would have lost my job

— CHARLOTTE

Destuted my reason for being countless sleepless nights days I stayed in a Depressed stat of mind the enlisted night mares the time robbed from a mother and her daughters over selfish reasonsing. The milestones the growth of the girls that can never be replaced. The unbearable [...]

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After all the accusations were denied by my children, they falsified my drug urine and hair follicle tests and denied to release my own test results, got retested and the hearing got moved to a phone call to having a hearing 3.5 weeks later after missing Christmas with my kids [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I hired a lawyer thinking he had our best interest in his negligence cost my family serious financial harm.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They have violated of my constitutional rights and have deprived me of my property by suspending my driver's license twice and without giving me a proper hearing before and enforcement acting was taking against

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I am traumatized by the court system and afraid to return into the court room. I am now taking anti- anxiety medications and would prefer to just disappear

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It's bullshit that they can literally follow someone everywhere they go and take videos of them without their knowledge and turn it in for Court

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> *This system turned an unsubstantiated investigation into court orders, contempt, arrest, and foster care without basic due process, and it has taken months of normal family life from us and our children. We have complied, stayed present, and fought to be heard, while our [...]*
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> — WILLIAM

They took everything from me I would have given willingly to keep my girls. My Name, My Career, My Education, My Church, My Community, My Possessions, My Friends, My Family.

— LACY

The system has not only ripped my family apart it has taken away valuable time with my sons. it is placed a huge burden on my immediate family and has built a wall between my mother and sister and me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They took our daughter when she was 4 days old..

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

my child was taken for missing 5 unexcused absences at the height of the COVID 19 pandemic, my son is not the same boy. they knew they were wrong and they didn't care.

— ANTHONY

The family court took an active, loving relationship away from me and my children, turning everyday life together into absence and loss. That separation has caused deep, lasting harm by breaking the bond that gave my children security and gave us our family.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Everyone else has left these 2 innocents babies Mike and I will continue the fight until our last breath. I don't need family that could do that to babies who can't fight for themselves!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

40 Mississippi parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 40 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — MISSISSIPPI

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Mississippi families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

> Took three healthy kids and emotionally abused them, along with their mother and maternal family, through repeated questioning by the court therapist, CPS, judge, and GAL. Took the children away from a loving mother based on false allegations, without due process or objective evidence. Full story is surreal. I consent to the use of my quotes as long as they do not mention or include mine or my children's private information. I copied and pasted from some of my open claims.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— RAMONA

Child Protection Services are suppose to protect children and if able under circumstances of reportance help in every way to keep families together. Their legal duty is to investigate, listen to children and family and do what they can to keep a family together, reunify, or place children where they are safe and can live a happy, healthy safe life to ensure a beautiful future. Instead this system takes their authority to in fact do the exact opposite. A mother of 4 that was very unprotected as a daughter resulting in being an overprotective mother, I will not let this system take that away from me for an anonymous report, laziness and their authority. I will fight until my kids are home and this systematic agency is broken, like they have done so many families !

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Emboldened an abuser to continue to abuse & oppress a mother & children after physical exodus. I've been disillusioned & no longer trust the system to help victims of abuse or represent the best interest of the children. I've learned the system is for abusers, not for their victims trying to survive in peace. Perjury doesn't exist in family court. Evidence is not necessary for lies to be believed. It doesn't matter what you can prove. It matters most where the judge's bias is.

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40 full approved Mississippi comments are included in this appendix.

07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a public, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Mississippi report comes from Mississippi respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Mississippi — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 71 Mississippi families reporting here are not the universe of Mississippi families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. Response counts and percentages use the number of families who answered that specific topic or financial field. The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – November 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

Dollar fields exclude blank, negative, and obvious data-entry artifact values above the report's field caps. When asset-loss values contain a strong statistical outlier, the asset-loss mean and total are suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county or regional field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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